

THE METHOD

An analyst or a team might begin a quality of information check by developing a database in which information is stored according to source type and date, with additional notations indicating strengths or weaknesses in those sources.⁴ Ideally, analysts would have a retrieval and search capability on the database, so that periodic reviews are less labor intensive and result in a more complete review of all sources used in past analysis. For the information review to be fully effective, analysts will need as much background information on sources as is feasible. Knowing the circumstances in which reporting was obtained is often critical to understanding its validity. With the data in hand, analysts can then:

- Review systematically all sources for accuracy.

⁴ Analysis of Competing Hypotheses (ACH), discussed later in the primer, is a useful technique for exploring the possibility that deception could explain the absence of evidence.

- Identify information sources that appear most critical or compelling.
- Check for sufficient and strong corroboration of critical reporting.
- Reexamine previously dismissed information in light of new facts or circumstances that cast it in a different light.
- Ensure that any recalled reporting is identified and properly flagged for other analysts; analysis based on recalled reporting should also be reviewed to determine if the reporting was essential to the judgments made.
- Consider whether ambiguous information has been interpreted and caveated properly.
- Indicate a level of confidence that analysts can place in sources, which are likely to figure in future analytic assessments.

Quality of Information Problem on Iraq

“ . . . Analysts community wide are unable to make fully informed judgments on the information they received, relying instead on nonspecific source lines to reach their assessments. Moreover, relevant operational data is nearly always withheld from analysts, putting them at a further analytical disadvantage . . . ”

—*Senate Select Committee on Intelligence, Report on the US Intelligence Community's Prewar Intelligence Assessments on Iraq*

“Analytic errors included over-reliance on a single, ambiguous source, [and, in addition to collection shortfalls] failure of analysts to understand fully the limitations of technical collection . . . ”

“The Intelligence Community relied too heavily on ambiguous imagery indicators . . . ”

—*Commission on the Intelligence Capabilities of the United States Regarding Weapons of Mass Destruction.*